

Women in Healthcare

MOST POWERFUL WOMEN - 2025

vironment where women can thrive because the sector is fundamentally built on trust, care and human connection,” says Ameera Shah, promoter and executive chairperson of Metropolis Healthcare. She says healthcare institutions have long been structured to support women, with systems, safety and workplace design creating an enabling environment.

Shobhana Kamineni, Promoter Director of Apollo Hospitals Enterprise Ltd and Executive Chairperson of Apollo Health Co Ltd, echoes this view. “Healthcare demands empathy, care and ability to take critical decisions,” she says, pointing to the traits that have historically drawn women into frontline clinical roles, public health services and nursing.

These structured and regulated environments, with defined shifts and predictable work rhythms, shape retention as much as entry. Dr Sadhna Joglekar, Senior Vice President and Head, Development India Hub, Novartis, believes the sector’s performance metrics and regulatory frameworks also create a transparent foundation for advancement. “Where women rise, it’s often because merit, performance and patient impact are visible, measurable and increasingly recognised,” she says.

PATHWAYS TO TOP

As more women in healthcare build technical and operational expertise, how can they move into enterprise leadership roles? Senior leaders in pharma, diagnostic and hospital segments say women dominate clinical, nursing and functional roles, but have historically been less exposed to revenue-bearing P&L responsibilities, the traditional pathway to the top of large healthcare organisations.

“Women are more often placed in staff or enabling roles rather than in commercially accountable line roles at C-suite level,” says Rajwinder Mehndwan, MD and CEO of Roche Pharma India. She says this limits commercial experience and financial decision-making exposure that are critical for senior leadership.

The pattern is more visible in pharma and biotech where Dasra’s 2023 analysis shows women occupy only 7.5% of leadership positions. Lower presence in industrial manufacturing, historically male networks in pharma operations and expectations of global mobility for certain roles have narrowed the leadership pool.

Leadership style, however, has never been the barrier. Women leaders say qualities required to reach the top are not the monopoly of any gender. “At the highest levels of leadership, the traits of an effective leader are consistent, regardless of gender,” says

Mehdwan. Dr Saloni Wagh, MD of Supriya Lifescience, shares her perspective from running a manufacturing operation. “The margin and scale outcomes depend not only on cost and volume but also on quality, regulatory approvals, global standards and people,” she says. In her experience, leaders who combine rigour with an ability to engage teams create more stable and future-ready organisations.

The value of inclusive decision-making comes up repeatedly in conversations with women leaders. “We wanted to make the right decisions for the business, but also create meaningful opportunities for our people to thrive,” says Mehndwan. Dr Joglekar recounts leading a multi-country transformation where a purely top-down approach seemed efficient on paper but would have undermined implementation. Choosing instead to co-create solutions helped reduce resistance and strengthened execution.

For many women aiming for senior roles, the skill sets they must consciously build follow

three broad themes: financial fluency, strategic risk-taking and visible advocacy. “To reach the top, women in healthcare need to aggressively develop a strategic mindset, agility and broad experience,” says Mehndwan.

Shah points out the mindset change required. “Women need to give themselves permission to aspire and to articulate that ambition without hesitation.” Kamineni frames it even more candidly. “Three skills which they

16

THE NUMBER OF HEALTHCARE COMPANIES FEATURED IN THE BT MPW LIST, MAKING IT THE MOST REPRESENTED SECTOR

₹23,537

THE COMBINED PAT OF THE 16 HEALTHCARE COMPANIES IN FY25, ACCOUNTING FOR 18% OF THE TOTAL PAT OF THE TOP 100 BT MPW COMPANIES

26%

THE INCREASE IN PAT FOR THE HEALTHCARE SECTOR, FROM ₹18,635 CRORE IN FY24 TO ₹23,537 CRORE IN FY25—THE HIGHEST AMONG MAJOR SECTORS ON THE LIST

